

**STUDY TITLE: AFRICAN COUNTRIES SCHEDULED TO HOLD  
ELECTIONS IN 2026**

**SUBSTUDY: A COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS WITH A FOCUS ON ZAMBIA,  
NIGERIA, KENYA, UGANDA, TANZANIA AND GHANA.**

**COMMISSIONED FOR: OPENGOV AFTRICA**

**RESEARCHER: KALIMUKWA LIKANDO [@LikandoAfrica]**

**COUNTRIES: ZAMBIA, NIGERIA, KENYA, UGANDA, TANZANIA AND  
GHANA.**

**SUBMISSION DATE: SATURDAY, 27 JUNE, 2026**

# CHAPTER ONE

## INTRODUCTION

### 1.0 Introduction

As of now, several African countries are scheduled to hold elections in 2026. While the specific dates may vary and may be subject to change, here are six (6) countries I have picked on that are expected to have elections this year, 2026:

- (a) Zambia: General elections, including presidential and parliamentary elections.
- (b) Nigeria: Presidential and National Assembly elections.
- (c) Kenya: General elections, including presidential, parliamentary and local elections.
- (d) Uganda: Presidential and parliamentary elections.
- (e) Tanzania: General elections, including presidential and parliamentary elections.
- (f) Ghana: Presidential and parliamentary elections.

Worth noting, however, is the fact that election dates may change. As such, it is advisable for all concerned to stay updated as the year rolls on.

### 1.1 Background of the Study

It is common knowledge that elections play a crucial role in shaping the political landscape of nations, serving as a vital mechanism for democratic participation and governance. In Africa, the electoral process has undergone significant transformations over the years, with many countries striving to establish and maintain democratic systems. However, the journey toward robust democracy is often challenged by political instability, corruption and issues surrounding electoral integrity and fairness.

In 2026, out of the many African nations that are scheduled to hold elections, I have picked on six African countries (that is, Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana). The named countries are scheduled to hold pivotal elections that will not only influence their domestic political environments but also have broader implications for regional stability and governance. Each of these countries presents a unique case study, reflecting diverse political histories, electoral systems and socio-economic contexts.

Zambia, known for its relatively peaceful transitions of power, faces the challenge of sustaining democratic practices in the face of economic difficulties and political polarization. Nigeria – Africa's most populous nation – is characterized by complex ethnic and religious dynamics that significantly impact its electoral politics, often leading to heightened tensions during election cycles. Kenya's elections are marked by intense political competition and ethnic mobilization, raising concerns about potential violence and electoral disputes. Uganda, under the long-standing leadership of President Yoweri Museveni, presents a case of entrenched power dynamics, where the struggle for political pluralism remains a critical issue. Tanzania has experienced a shift toward increased political repression in recent years, with opposition parties facing significant challenges

and, while Ghana is often regarded as a beacon of democratic stability in West Africa, it continues to confront issues related to governance and electoral fairness.

This research study aimed at providing a comprehensive analysis of the upcoming elections in these six countries, focusing on the types of elections (ranging from presidential to parliamentary) and the key political players involved. Additionally, the study explored voter demographics, historical voting trends and the anticipated challenges each country may face in the lead-up to the elections. By examining these factors, the researcher sought to contribute to a deeper understanding of the electoral processes in these nations and their implications for democracy in Africa.

Ultimately, the findings of this study will be valuable for policymakers, civil society organizations and scholars interested in the evolving political dynamics of Africa. By highlighting both the progress made and the challenges that persist, this research aimed at informing strategies for promoting democratic governance and electoral integrity across the continent.

## **1.2 The Importance of Elections in Democratic Governance**

Elections are often heralded as the cornerstone of democratic governance, providing a structured process through which citizens can express their political preferences and hold their leaders accountable. In the context of Africa, where many nations have experienced a tumultuous history of colonialism, authoritarian rule and civil conflict, the significance of elections extends beyond mere procedural democracy; they embody the aspirations of citizens for representation, participation as well as the rule of law.

**1.2.1 Expression of Popular Will:** Elections serve as a vital mechanism for citizens to voice their opinions and influence government policies. In African nations, where diverse ethnic and cultural groups coexist, elections provide an opportunity for various communities to assert their interests and priorities. This expression of popular will is essential for fostering a sense of belonging and national identity among the citizens.

**1.2.2 Accountability and Transparency:** Regular elections create a framework for political accountability, compelling leaders to respond to the needs and concerns of their constituents. In many African countries, where corruption and mismanagement have historically undermined governance, the electoral process acts as a check on power. By enabling citizens to vote out ineffective or corrupt leaders, elections promote transparency and encourage better governance practices.

**1.2.3 Conflict Resolution and Peacebuilding:** In regions where ethnic tensions and historical grievances persist, elections can serve as a peaceful means of conflict resolution. By providing a platform for competing interests to be articulated and negotiated, elections can help mitigate tensions and foster social cohesion. However, this potential is contingent upon the integrity of the electoral process; flawed elections can exacerbate divisions and lead to violence.

**1.2.4 Strengthening Democratic Institutions:** Elections are instrumental in building and reinforcing democratic institutions. In Africa, where many countries are still in the process of consolidating their democratic frameworks, credible elections contribute to the legitimacy of political institutions, including parliaments, judiciary systems, and electoral commissions. Strong institutions are essential for upholding the rule of law and protecting human rights.

**1.2.5 Encouraging Civic Engagement:** The electoral process encourages civic participation beyond just voting. It mobilizes citizens to engage in political discourse, advocate for their rights and participate in civil society organizations. This active engagement is crucial for nurturing a politically informed and active citizenry – which is fundamental for the health of any democracy.

**1.2.6 International Perception and Relations:** Elections also play a significant role in shaping a country's international standing. Credible and transparent electoral processes can enhance a nation's reputation, attracting foreign investment and fostering diplomatic relations. Conversely, disputed elections can lead to sanctions, isolation and a loss of credibility on the global stage.

### **1.3 Purpose and Objectives of This Research**

The purpose of this research study was to conduct a thorough analysis of the elections scheduled for 2026 in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana. By focusing on these six countries, the study aimed at illuminating the electoral processes, political dynamics and socio-economic contexts that shape the upcoming elections. Understanding these factors is essential for assessing the health of democracy in these nations and the broader African continent.

To achieve this purpose, the research was guided by several specific objectives, as outlined below:-

**1.3.1 To Investigate Electoral Systems and Frameworks:** The study examined the electoral laws, regulations and institutional frameworks governing the elections in each of the six countries. This included analyzing how these systems facilitate or impede democratic participation and the overall integrity of the electoral process.

**1.3.2 To Profile Key Political Actors:** The research sought to identify and analyze the major political parties, candidates and coalitions participating in the 2026 elections. Understanding the motivations, strategies and historical contexts of these political actors will provide insights into the competitive landscape and potential electoral outcomes.

**1.3.3 To Analyze Voter Demographics and Behavior:** The study explored the demographics of the electorate, including factors such as age, gender, ethnicity and

socio-economic status. Additionally, it examined historical voting trends and patterns to understand how these demographics influence voter behavior and engagement in the electoral process.

**1.3.4 To Assess Challenges and Risks:** The research identified potential challenges and risks associated with the electoral process, including issues such as political violence, electoral fraud, media bias and restrictions on civil liberties. By understanding these challenges, the study aimed at evaluating the overall credibility and fairness of the elections.

**1.3.5 To Conduct a Comparative Analysis:** By comparing the electoral dynamics across the six countries, the study has highlighted both commonalities and differences in their approaches to governance and electoral practices. This comparative perspective will enhance the understanding of regional trends and the impact of local contexts on democratic processes.

**1.3.6 To Provide Policy Recommendations:** Based on the findings, the research has offered actionable recommendations for policymakers, civil society organizations and electoral bodies. These recommendations will focus on strategies to enhance electoral integrity, promote civic engagement and ensure inclusive governance.

**1.3.7 To Contribute to Academic and Public Discourse:** The study aimed at enriching the academic discourse on democracy and governance in Africa by providing a well-researched analysis of the upcoming elections. This contribution will be valuable for scholars, practitioners and students interested in understanding the complexities of electoral politics within the African region.

## **1.4 Scope of the Study**

The scope of this research study was defined by the geographical, temporal and thematic boundaries that frame the analysis of the elections scheduled for 2026 in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana. By delineating the scope, the study aimed at focusing its efforts on specific aspects of the electoral processes in these countries while acknowledging the broader context of democratic governance in Africa.

**1.4.1 Geographical Scope:** The researcher concentrated on six African countries (Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana). Each of these nations has been selected due to their scheduled elections in 2026 and their varying political contexts, which provide a rich ground for comparative analysis. The study explored the unique political histories, electoral systems and socio-economic conditions of each country, allowing for a nuanced understanding of their electoral dynamics.

**1.4.2 Temporal Scope:** The primary focus of the study was on the electoral events that would be occurring in 2026. However, the researcher also considered historical contexts by examining past elections, political developments and trends leading up to 2026. This historical perspective was essential for understanding the evolution of electoral practices and the factors that could most likely influence the upcoming elections.

**1.4.3 Thematic Scope:** The study also addressed several key themes related to the electoral processes in the selected countries, which included:-

- **Electoral Systems and Frameworks:** Analyzing the legal and institutional structures that govern elections.
- **Political Actors:** Identifying and profiling major political parties, candidates and coalitions.
- **Voter Demographics and Behavior:** Examining the characteristics of the electorate and historical voting patterns.
- **Challenges and Risks:** Assessing potential obstacles to free and fair elections, such as political violence, electoral fraud and media bias.
- **A Comparative Analysis:** Highlighting similarities and differences in electoral dynamics across the six countries.

**1.4.4 Limitations of the Study:** While the research aimed at providing a comprehensive analysis, it was important to acknowledge certain limitations. The study primarily relied on secondary data sources, including academic literature, government reports and media coverage. It is possible that these may not have captured all nuances of the electoral processes. Additionally, the dynamic nature of political events might lead to changes in the electoral landscape as the elections approach – and this is something which could impact the findings.

**1.4.5 Target Audience:** The findings of this research will be relevant to a diverse audience, including policymakers, civil society organizations, electoral bodies, scholars and students interested in African politics and democratic governance. By providing insights into the electoral processes and challenges in the named countries, the study aimed at informing strategies for promoting electoral integrity and enhancing democratic practices.

## **CHAPTER TWO METHODOLOGY**

### **2.0 Research Design**

Below is a research design adopted for the study which focused on African nations that are scheduled to hold elections in the year 2026, with the spotlight on Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana.

### **2.1 Research Design**

#### **2.1.1 Title of the Study:**

The title of the work was decided as *“African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026: A Comparative Analysis with a Focus on Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, and Ghana.”*

#### **2.1.2 Research Objectives:**

- To analyze the political landscape and electoral processes in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana in the run-up to the 2026 elections.
- To identify the key issues and challenges each of the six countries would most likely face in the electoral process.
- To assess the role of civil society and international observers in promoting fair elections.
- To evaluate the impact of past elections on the current political dynamics.

#### **2.1.3 Research Questions:**

The following were designated as the research questions for this particular research:-

- What are the political contexts and electoral systems in the selected countries?
- What challenges do these countries face in conducting free and fair elections?
- How do civil society organizations and international bodies influence the electoral process?
- What lessons can be learned from previous elections that took place in these countries?

#### **2.1.4 Methodology:**

Research Design: Comparative qualitative study.

##### **(a) Data Collection Methods:**

These amounted to:-

- **Document Analysis:** Review of existing literature, electoral laws and reports from previous elections.
- **Interviews:** Conducted semi-structured interviews with key stakeholders, including electoral commission officials, political party representatives, civil society members and voters.
- **Focus Groups:** Organized focus group discussions with citizens to gather insights on their perceptions of the electoral process and issues of concern.
- **Sampling:** Purposive sampling to select participants who had relevant knowledge and experience regarding the electoral processes in their respective countries.

##### **(b) Data Analysis:**

- Used thematic analysis to identify and analyze patterns and themes from qualitative data collected through interviews and focus groups.
- Comparative analysis to highlight similarities and differences in electoral processes and challenges across the selected countries.

##### **(c) Ethical Considerations:**

- Obtained informed consent from all participants.
- Ensured confidentiality and anonymity of all the respondents.
- Was transparent about the purpose of the research and how the data would be used.

#### **2.1.5 Timeline:**

- **Phase 1:** Literature Review and Document Analysis (Week 1 – Week 3).
- **Phase 2:** Data Collection (Interviews and Focus Groups) (Week 4 – Week 5).
- **Phase 3:** Data Analysis (Week 6).
- **Phase 4:** Report Writing and Dissemination of Findings (Week 7 – Week 8).

#### **2.1.6 Expected Outcomes:**

- A comprehensive report detailing the electoral landscape in the selected countries.
- Recommendations for stakeholders on improving electoral processes and ensuring fairness in the scheduled upcoming elections.
- Contributions to academic literature on electoral studies on the African continent.



### 2.1.7 Limitations:

- Potential biases in participant responses.
- Access to certain political figures or sensitive information was restricted.

## 2.2 Data Collection Methods

Below is a detailed outline of the Data Collection Methods used by the researcher for the study on *African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026*, with a focus on primary and secondary sources, specifically emphasizing Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana.

### 2.2.1 Primary Sources

#### (a) Interviews

- **Purpose:** To gather in-depth qualitative data from key stakeholders involved in the electoral process.
- **Participants:**
  - ✓ Electoral commission officials from each country.
  - ✓ Political party representatives.
  - ✓ Civil society leaders and activists.
  - ✓ Academics and political analysts with expertise in electoral processes.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Developed a semi-structured interview guide with open-ended questions to facilitate discussion while allowing flexibility based on participant responses.
  - ✓ Conducted interviews either in person, via phone or through video conferencing, depending on accessibility and participant preference.
  - ✓ When consented to, recorded the interviews for accurate transcription and thematic analysis.

#### (b) Surveys

- **Purpose:** To collect quantitative data on public opinion regarding the electoral process, voter engagement and key issues affecting elections.
- **Participants:**
  - ✓ A representative sample of voters from each selected country.

- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Developed a structured questionnaire with both closed and open-ended questions to capture a range of opinions.
  - ✓ Distributed the survey online or through face-to-face interviews, ensuring accessibility for participants.
  - ✓ Ensured the survey was available in local languages where necessary to maximize participation and understanding.
  - ✓ Analyzed survey data using statistical methods to identify trends and correlations.

## 2.2.2 Secondary Sources

### (a) Academic Articles

- **Purpose:** To review existing literature on electoral processes, political dynamics and historical contexts in the selected countries.
- **Sources:**
  - ✓ Peer-reviewed journals focusing on political science, African studies and electoral studies.
  - ✓ Theses and dissertations from universities that examine electoral issues in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Conducted a systematic literature review using academic databases such as JSTOR, Google Scholar and online university library resources.
  - ✓ Summarized key findings and theoretical frameworks relevant to the study.

### (b) Government Reports

- **Purpose:** To gather official data and insights on electoral laws, regulations and previous election outcomes.
- **Sources:**
  - ✓ Reports from electoral commissions in each country detailing past elections, voter turnout and electoral reforms.
  - ✓ Legislative documents outlining electoral laws and regulations.

- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Accessed government websites and official publications to collect relevant reports and documents.
  - ✓ Analyzed the content for insights on the electoral framework and historical context.

### **(c) NGO and International Organization Reports\*\***

- **Purpose:** To understand the role of civil society and international observers in the electoral process.
- **Sources:**
  - ✓ Reports from organizations such as the African Union, ECOWAS, Transparency International and local NGOs focused on democracy and governance.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Reviewed reports and assessments of past elections, including recommendations for improving electoral integrity.
  - ✓ Extracted relevant data and insights that can inform the current study.

### **(d) Media Reports**

- **Purpose:** To capture public discourse and media coverage surrounding the electoral processes in the selected countries.
- **Sources:**
  - ✓ News articles, opinion pieces and editorial content from reputable local and international media outlets.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Conducted a media analysis to identify key themes, narratives and public sentiments regarding the upcoming elections.
  - ✓ Used the media archives and online news platforms to gather relevant articles and reports.

Below is a detailed outline of the *Data Analysis Techniques* for the research study on *African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026*, with a special focus on Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana.

## 2.3 Data Analysis Techniques

### 2.3.1 Qualitative Data Analysis

#### (a) Thematic Analysis

- **Purpose:** To identify, analyze, and report patterns (themes) within qualitative data collected from interviews and focus groups.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Transcribed interviews and focus group discussions verbatim.
  - ✓ The researcher familiarized himself with the data by reading through the transcripts multiple times.
  - ✓ Generated initial codes by highlighting significant phrases or concepts related to the research questions.
  - ✓ Grouped the codes into broader themes that captured the essence of the data.
  - ✓ Reviewed and refined the themes to ensure that they accurately represented the data and aligned with the research objectives.
  - ✓ Wrote up the findings, illustrating each theme with quotes from participants to provide context and depth.

#### (b) Content Analysis

- **Purpose:** To systematically analyze the content of documents, reports and media articles related to the electoral processes in the selected countries.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Identified key documents (such as, government reports, NGO assessments, media articles) that were relevant to the study.
  - ✓ Developed a coding scheme based on predefined categories (for example, electoral challenges, public sentiment, civil society involvement).
  - ✓ Analyzed the frequency and context of specific themes or keywords within the documents.
  - ✓ Summarized findings to highlight trends, discrepancies and insights regarding the electoral landscape.

## 2.3.2 Quantitative Data Analysis

### (a) Descriptive Statistics

- **Purpose:** To summarize and describe the main features of the quantitative data collected through surveys.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Used statistical software (such as, SPSS, R, or Excel) to input survey data.
  - ✓ Calculated measures of central tendency (mean, median, mode) and measures of dispersion (standard deviation, range) to understand the distribution of responses.
  - ✓ Created visual representations (for example, graphs, charts) to illustrate key findings and trends.

### (b) Inferential Statistics

- **Purpose:** To draw conclusions and make inferences about the population based on the survey sample data.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Conducted hypothesis testing to determine if there were significant differences or relationships between variables (for example, demographic factors and voting intentions).
  - ✓ Used statistical tests such as the chi-square tests for categorical data or t-tests/ANOVA for continuous data, depending on the research question(s).
  - ✓ Reported p-values and confidence intervals to assess the statistical significance of the findings.

### (c) Correlation Analysis

- **Purpose:** To examine the relationships between different variables in the survey data.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Calculated correlation coefficients (such as, Pearson or Spearman) to assess the strength and direction of relationships between variables (for example, trust in electoral institutions and likelihood of voting).
  - ✓ Interpreted the results to identify significant correlations and their implications for the electoral process.

### 2.3.3 Comparative Analysis

#### (a) Cross-Country Comparison

- **Purpose:** To compare and contrast the electoral processes, challenges and public sentiments across the selected countries.
- **Procedure:**
  - ✓ Synthesized findings from qualitative and quantitative analyses to identify similarities and differences in electoral dynamics.
  - ✓ Used a comparative framework to assess how historical, cultural and political contexts have so far influenced the electoral processes in each country.
  - ✓ Highlighted key lessons learned and best practices that can be applied to improve electoral integrity throughout the African region.

Outlined below is a detailed *Limitations of the Study* for the research study on *African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026* and the researcher was especially focusing on the countries of Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana.

### 2.4 Limitations of the Study

#### 2.4.1 Access to Information:

- **Description:** Some electoral data and reports were restricted or difficult to obtain due to political sensitivities, especially in countries with less transparent governance.
- **Impact:** This limitation hindered a comprehensive understanding of the electoral processes and challenges in those particular countries.

#### 2.4.2 Participant Bias:

- **Description:** Interviews and focus group discussions were subject to bias because participants tended to provide socially desirable responses or were reluctant to share critical views about the electoral process or the government.
- **Impact:** This phenomenon affected the authenticity of the qualitative data collected, and most likely potentially skewed the findings.

### 2.4.3 Sample Representativeness:

- **Description:** The selection of interview and survey participants did not fully represent the diverse demographics of each country, particularly in terms of socio-economic status, education and geographical location.
- **Impact:** This limited the generalizability of the findings and most likely overlooked the perspectives of the marginalized groups.

### 2.4.4 Language Barriers:

- **Description:** Conducting interviews and surveys in multiple languages most probably presented challenges in accurately capturing the participants' responses and nuances in their expressions.
- **Impact:** Misinterpretation or loss of meaning during translation most likely affected the quality of the data collected.

### 2.4.5 Temporal Constraints:

- **Description:** The study was time-bound, focusing on the electoral processes leading up to the 2026 elections. It is possible that, by the time the elections take place, political dynamics may have changed, thereby, impacting the relevance of the findings.
- **Impact:** Because of the above, findings may become outdated or less applicable if significant political events occur after the study was conducted.

### 2.4.6 Limited Scope:

- **Description:** The focus on only six African countries may not capture the full diversity of electoral experiences across the entire African continent.
- **Impact:** This limitation could highly restrict the ability to draw broader conclusions about electoral processes in Africa as a whole.

### 2.4.7 Reliability of Secondary Sources:

- **Description:** The study heavily relied on secondary data from various sources, including government reports, academic articles and media coverage – and this could immensely vary in reliability and objectivity.
- **Impact:** As such, inconsistent or biased reporting contained in the secondary sources could affect the validity of the findings.

#### **2.4.8 Resource Constraints:**

- **Description:** The limited funding, time and personnel probably restricted the depth of data collection and analysis, particularly in conducting extensive fieldwork or reaching a larger sample size.
- **Impact:** This most probably resulted in a less comprehensive analysis than originally intended.

#### **2.4.9 Political Sensitivity:**

- **Description:** The political context in some of the selected countries may have led to reluctance among participants to discuss electoral issues openly, particularly in environments where dissent is discouraged.
- **Impact:** This could have limited the richness of the qualitative data and the ability to capture critical insights.



## **CHAPTER THREE COUNTRY PROFILES**

### **3.0 Introduction**

What follows below are the country profiles for Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana, which are discussed under the overview, political history, current political landscape and electoral systems subheadings for each country.

### **3.1 Zambia**

#### **3.1.1 Overview:**

Zambia is a landlocked country in Southern Africa, known for its rich copper resources and diverse wildlife. The nation's capital city is Lusaka.

#### **3.1.2 Political History:**

Zambia gained independence from British colonial rule in 1964. Initially, it was a one-party state under President Kenneth David Kaunda, who ruled until 1991 when multiparty democracy was introduced by the late President Fredrick Titus Jacob Chiluba. From that time, Zambia has experienced a series of elections – some of which have been marked by political tensions and allegations of electoral fraud.

#### **3.1.3 Current Political Landscape:**

As of 2023, Zambia's political landscape has been characterized by a competitive multiparty system. The United Party for National Development (UPND) currently holds power, with Hakainde Hichilema serving as president after winning the 2021 elections. The opposition, particularly the Patriotic Front (PF), remains influential and, apart from tribalism, political discourse often revolves around issues of governance, corruption and economic challenges.

#### **3.1.4 The Electoral System:**

Zambia employs a mixed electoral system. The president is elected through a simple majority vote in a direct election, while the National Assembly consists of members elected through a combination of first-past-the-post and proportional representation systems.

## **3.2 Nigeria**

### **3.2.1 Overview:**

Nigeria is Africa's most populous country, located in West Africa, with a diverse mix of ethnicities, languages and cultures. The country's capital city is Abuja.

### **3.2.2 Political History:**

Nigeria gained independence from British colonial rule in 1960. The country has experienced a number of military coups and civil conflicts, notably the Nigerian Civil War of 1967 to 1970. Since the country's return to civilian rule in 1999, Nigeria has maintained a democratic system, although this has been marred by such challenges as corruption, ethnic tensions as well as security issues, particularly with the emergence of such insurgent groups like Boko Haram.

### **3.2.3 The Current Political Landscape:**

Nigeria's political landscape is dominated by two major parties: the All Progressives Congress (APC) and the People's Democratic Party (PDP). The current president, Muhammadu Buhari, from the All Progressives Congress, has been in office from the year 2015. The political environment is often contentious, with ongoing debates about governance, security and economic reforms.

### **3.2.4 The Electoral System:**

Nigeria uses a modified two-round system for presidential elections, requiring a candidate to receive a majority of votes and at least 25% of votes in two-thirds of the states. The National Assembly consists of a bicameral legislature – with the members elected through first-past-the-post voting.

## **3.3 Kenya**

### **3.3.1 Overview:**

Kenya is located in the East African region and is known for its diverse landscapes, wildlife and cultural heritage. The nation's capital city is Nairobi.

### **3.3.2 Political History:**

Kenya gained independence from British colonial rule in 1963. The country has experienced political instability, including ethnic violence and contested elections, particularly after the 2007 elections, which led to significant unrest. The 2010 constitution introduced significant reforms aimed at decentralizing power and enhancing democratic governance.

### **3.3.3 Current Political Landscape:**

As of 2023, Kenya's political landscape has been characterized by a multiparty system, with the *Kenya Kwanza Alliance* and the *Azimio la Umoja* coalition being the main political groupings. President William Ruto, elected into office in 2022, faces challenges related to economic recovery, corruption and ethnic divisions in that country.

### **3.3.4 The Electoral System:**

Kenya employs a two-round system for presidential elections, requiring a candidate to secure a majority of the votes cast. The National Assembly consists of a bicameral legislature, with members elected through first-past-the-post voting.

## **3.4 Uganda**

### **3.4.1 Overview:**

Uganda is also located in East Africa and is a country known for its diverse ecosystems and Lake Victoria. The capital city for this country is Kampala.

### **3.4.2 Political History:**

Uganda gained independence from British colonial rule in 1962. The country has since experienced significant political turmoil, including the brutal regime of Idi Amin in the 1970s and subsequent civil conflicts. President Yoweri Museveni has been in power since 1986, initially coming to power through a guerrilla war and later transitioning to a more formal political system.

### **3.4.3 Current Political Landscape:**

Uganda's political landscape is dominated by the National Resistance Movement (NRM), led by Museveni. The political environment is characterized by limited opposition, with allegations of repression and human rights abuses against dissenters. In recent elections, opposition candidates have faced significant challenges, including arrests and violence.

### **3.4.4 Electoral System:**

Uganda uses a modified first-past-the-post system for presidential elections, with the president elected for a five-year term. The Parliament is bicameral, consisting of the House of Representatives and the Senate, with members elected through a combination of first-past-the-post and proportional representation.

## **3.5 Tanzania**

### **3.5.1 Overview:**

Tanzania is as well located in East Africa and the country is known for its wildlife and Mount Kilimanjaro. The country's capital city is Dodoma.

### **3.5.2 Political History:**

Tanzania gained independence from British colonial rule in 1961. The country was initially a one-party state under President Julius Nyerere, who promoted *socialism*. In the 1990s, Tanzania transitioned to a multiparty system, but the ruling party, Chama Cha Mapinduzi (CCM), has maintained significant control over the political landscape.

### **3.5.3 Current Political Landscape:**

As of 2023, Tanzania's political landscape has been dominated by the Chama Cha Mapinduzi, with President Samia Suluhu Hassan, who succeeded John Magufuli in 2021. The opposition faces challenges, including restrictions on political activities and access to the media. Key issues include governance, economic development and human rights.

### **3.5.4 Electoral System:**

Tanzania employs a first-past-the-post system for presidential elections, with the president elected for a five-year term. The National Assembly consists of members elected through a combination of direct elections and appointed representatives.

## **3.6 Ghana**

### **3.6.1 Overview:**

The country of Ghana is located in the West African region and is known for its rich history and cultural diversity. The nation's capital city is Accra.

### **3.6.2 Political History:**

Ghana gained independence from British colonial rule in 1957 and was the first African country to do so. The country has experienced periods of military rule and political instability but it has established a stable democratic system since the 1990s, with regular elections and peaceful transfers of power.

### **3.6.3 Current Political Landscape:**

As of 2023, Ghana's political landscape has been characterized by a competitive multiparty system, primarily dominated by the New Patriotic Party (NPP) and the National Democratic Congress (NDC). The current president, Nana Akufo-Addo, has been in office since 2017, focusing on economic development and social policies.

### **3.6.4 Electoral System:**

Ghana uses a two-round system for presidential elections, requiring a candidate to secure a majority of the votes cast. The Parliament is unicameral, with members elected through first-past-the-post voting.

These country profiles provide an overview of the political history, current political landscape and electoral systems for the countries of Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana – offering rich insights into the context of the upcoming elections this year, 2026.

## CHAPTER FOUR

### ELECTIONS SCHEDULED FOR 2026

#### 4.0 Introduction

For each of the six countries selected for this research study, the researcher focused on the type of election, the key details about the election; that is, the current political party in power, the major political parties participating in the election, the voter demographics and turnout trends (taking a leaf from previous elections in the particular country) as well as the anticipated challenges and issues for that specific country.

#### 4.1 Zambia

##### 4.1.1 The Type of Election:

- The country of Zambia will be holding general elections (that is, both *Presidential* and *Parliamentary* elections at the same time).

##### 4.1.2 Key Details:

###### (a) Current Political Party in Power:

- The United Party for National Development (UPND) is the current ruling party in Zambia. Led by Hakainde Hichilema, who became president after winning the country's August 2021 elections, the United Party for National Development has focused on economic reforms, anti-corruption measures as well as improving social services. President Hichilema's administration has emphasized the need for transparency and accountability in governance, aiming at restoring public trust in political institutions.

###### (b) The Major Political Parties Participating:

- The **United Party for National Development (UPND)**: This is the country's ruling party under President Hakainde Hichilema and it is advocating for economic growth, social justice and good governance. It is worth noting that the UPND is in a formal political coalition known as the UPND Alliance. Formed ahead of the 2021 elections and expanded leading up to the 2026 general elections, the coalition backs President Hakainde Hichilema. This coalition is comprised of the Alliance for Democracy and Development (ADD), the New Nation Party (NNP), the Movement for Multiparty Democracy (MMD), the Movement for Democratic Change (MDC), the Patriotic Front (PF - faction), the United National Independence Party (UNIP), the National Democratic Congress (NDC), the National Restoration Party (NAREP), the Republican Progressive Party (RPP), the United Prosperous and Peaceful Zambia (UPPZ), the United Progressive People (UPP), the Democratic Party (DP), the National Congress Party (NCP) as well as the Party of National Unity and Progress (PNUP).

- The **Patriotic Front (PF)**: This is the country's main opposition party. The party held power from 2011 until 2021. The Patriotic Front and a number of fellow opposition parties formed the *Tonse Alliance* in November, 2024 with the sole aim of unseating the UPND in the 2026 General Elections. Member of Parliament Brian Mundubile was elected as the alliance's presidential candidate with the Forum for Democracy and Development (FDD) chosen as the party to be used by the alliance at the election.
- The **People's Pact**, a movement consisting of civil society and political parties is expected to field Fred M'membe of the Socialist Party (SP).
- The **Citizens First (CF)** Orange Alliance (including such members as Saboi Imboela – President of the National Democratic Congress) has endorsed Harry Kalaba.
- The **Democratic Party (DP)** (under President Judith Kabemba) is a smaller opposition party that aimed at providing an alternative to the dominant parties and focused on democratic governance and social issues. However, the DP later u-turned and threw its weight behind President Hakainde Hichilema ahead of the 2026 General Election, citing his record on education and mining as key reasons for the endorsement. The party, however, would continue to field its own candidates at parliamentary, mayoral and ward levels, signalling a coalition approach rather than a full merger of electoral effort.
- The **People's Alliance for Change (PAC)**, led by Andyford Mayele Banda, is another emerging party that seeks to represent the interests of the youth and marginalized communities. The **Organized People's Party (OPP)** and the People's Alliance for Change (PAC) have formed an electoral alliance and endorsed a joint presidential ticket for the August 13, 2026 General Elections, with the OPP president, Dr. Brian Mushimba, named as presidential candidate while the PAC leader, Andyford Mayele Banda, will serve as Dr. Mushimba's running mate.
- **Other Smaller Parties and Individuals**: Various other smaller parties and individuals [such as Zambia Must Prosper (ZMP) under Kelvin Bwalya, the Movement For Economic Emancipation (MEE) led by Given Chansa, the Liberal Democrats Party (LDP) under Xavier Chungu, the Citizens First (CF) Party under Harry Kalaba, Given Katuta running as an Independent Candidate, the Zambia Wake-Up Party (ZAWAPA) under Howard Kunda, the Democratic Union (DU) led by Njovu Ackim, the Christian Democratic Party (CDP) led by Daniel Pule, the New Focus Party (NFP) under Richwell Siamunene as well as the– Labour Movement (LM) led by Richard Sihumba] are also likely to participate in the upcoming 2026 General Elections, contributing to a diverse political landscape in Zambia.

### (c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:

- **Voter Demographics**: Zambia has a youthful population, with a significant portion of registered voters under the age of 35. Urban areas, particularly Lusaka and the Copperbelt region, have higher concentrations of voters compared to rural areas, where turnout may be lower due to accessibility issues and voter education gaps.

- **Turnout Trends:** In the 2021 elections, voter turnout was approximately 70%, indicating a strong engagement among the electorate. Factors influencing turnout in Zambia included heightened political awareness, effective voter mobilization campaigns as well as the perceived stakes of the elections. The upcoming 2026 elections will likely see continued efforts to engage the younger voters and increase participation – especially in the rural places.

#### **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:**

- **Political Tensions:** The political atmosphere leading up to the 2026 elections in Zambia may be fraught with tensions between the ruling UPND and the main opposition Patriotic Front, something that can potentially lead to confrontations and unrest – especially if accusations of electoral malpractice should arise.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Concerns about the independence and effectiveness of the Electoral Commission of Zambia (ECZ) may surface, particularly regarding the transparency of the voter registration process and the conduct of the elections.
- **Economic Challenges:** Economic issues, including inflation, unemployment and public service delivery, will likely dominate the electoral discourse. Voters may prioritize candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Voter Education and Participation:** Ensuring that voters are well-informed about the electoral process and motivated to participate in the voting will be crucial. This is particularly important for younger voters and those in rural areas who may face barriers to such engagements.
- **Security Concerns:** The potential for violence or intimidation during the election period could pose significant challenges to a peaceful electoral process. As such, ensuring the safety of voters and candidates will be essential for maintaining public confidence in the electoral system.

It is worth noting that the 2026 general elections in Zambia will be a critical juncture for the country's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. Understanding the current political landscape, key parties, voter demographics and anticipated challenges will, therefore, be essential for analyzing the electoral process and its outcomes. This comprehensive overview sets the stage for further exploration of the electoral context in Zambia as the elections approach.



## 4.2 Nigeria

### 4.2.1 Type of Election:

- General Elections (Presidential and Parliamentary)

### 4.2.2 Key Details:

#### (a) Current Political Party in Power:

- The All Progressives Congress (APC) is the current ruling party in Nigeria. The APC has been in power since 2015, with President Muhammadu Buhari serving two terms. As of 2023, the APC has been preparing for the upcoming 2026 elections, with significant focus on addressing the various challenges facing the country, including security issues, economic recovery and governance reforms.

#### (b) Major Political Parties Participating:

- **All Progressives Congress (APC):** The ruling party is expected to field a candidate which the party can trust to continue its governance agenda. So far, the APC has focused on economic development and security but the party still faces criticism over its handling of a number of issues.
- **People's Democratic Party (PDP):** This is the main opposition party, which was in power from 1999 until 2015. The PDP aims at regaining power by addressing public dissatisfaction with the APC's governance and presenting a strong alternative platform.
- **Labour Party (LP):** This is an emerging political force, particularly after the 2023 elections, where it gained significant support, especially among the younger voters. The Labour Party is focused on social justice, economic reforms and also on addressing youth unemployment.
- **Other Political Parties:** Various other smaller political parties, including the Social Democratic Party (SDP) and regional parties, are also likely participate;thereby, contributing to a diverse political landscape.

#### (c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:

- **Voter Demographics:** Nigeria has a young and diverse population, with a significant portion of registered voters under the age of 35. Urban areas, particularly in the South and Middle Belt regions, tend to have higher voter engagement compared to the rural areas in the North.
- **Turnout Trends:** Voter turnout during the 2023 elections was approximately 29%, reflecting a decline compared to previous elections. Factors influencing turnout included voter apathy, security concerns and logistical challenges. The 2026 elections will likely see efforts to mobilize voters, particularly the younger demographics, as a way of increasing participation.

#### **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:**

- **Security Concerns:** Nigeria faces significant security challenges, including insurgency in the Northeast (Boko Haram), banditry in the Northwest, and separatist movements in the Southeast. These issues could impact voter turnout and the overall electoral process.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Concerns about the transparency and credibility of the electoral process may arise, particularly regarding the independence of the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) and allegations of electoral malpractice.
- **Economic Challenges:** Economic issues, including inflation, unemployment and poverty, will most likely dominate the electoral discourse. Voters may look up to and prioritize candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Political Polarization:** The political landscape in Nigeria is often polarized along ethnic and regional lines. This could lead to heightened tensions during the election period. Also, candidates will need to appeal to a broad coalition to secure votes.
- **Voter Education and Engagement:** Ensuring that voters are well-informed about the electoral process and motivated to participate in the voting will be crucial. Efforts to enhance voter education and engagement, particularly among the younger voters, will be essential for a successful electoral outcome.

The 2026 general elections in Nigeria will be a pivotal moment for the country's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. This overview endeavored to provide a foundation for further exploration of the electoral context in Nigeria as the elections draw closer.

### **4.3 Kenya**

#### **4.3.1 Type of Election:**

- General elections ( to mean, Presidential and Parliamentary elections).

#### **4.3.2 Key Details:**

##### **(a) Current Political Party in Power:**

- **The Kenya Kwanza Alliance** is the current ruling coalition, led by President William Ruto, who assumed office after winning the presidential election in August, 2022. Ruto's administration has focused on economic recovery, job creation and addressing issues related to food security and corruption.

## **(b) Major Political Parties Participating:**

- **The Kenya Kwanza Alliance:** This is the ruling coalition which includes several parties, primarily the United Democratic Alliance (UDA), led by Ruto. The coalition aims at consolidating power and continuing its governance agenda.
- **Azimio la Umoja Coalition:** The main opposition coalition, led by former Prime Minister Raila Odinga and comprising several parties, including the Orange Democratic Movement (ODM). The coalition seeks to challenge the ruling party by addressing issues of governance, electoral reforms and public service delivery.
- **Other Political Parties:** Various other smaller parties, such as the Wiper Democratic Movement (WDM) and the Kenya African National Union (KANU) are also likely to participate – something that will contribute to a diverse political landscape.

## **(c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:**

- **Voter Demographics:** Kenya has a youthful population, with a significant proportion of registered voters being under the age of 35. The urban areas, especially Nairobi and Mombasa, tend to have higher voter engagement compared to the rural places.
- **Turnout Trends:** Voter turnout in the 2022 elections was approximately 65%, reflecting a relatively high level of engagement. Factors influencing turnout included the competitive nature of the elections, voter education initiatives, as well as the mobilization efforts made by the different political parties. The 2026 elections will likely see continued efforts to engage the younger voters and strategies to increase participation in rural areas.

## **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:\*\***

- **Political Tensions:** The political environment in the run-up to the 2026 elections may likely be marked by tensions between the ruling coalition and the opposition, particularly if allegations of electoral malpractice arise or if there should be disputes over election outcomes.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Concerns about the independence and effectiveness of the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC) may likely surface, particularly regarding the transparency of the voter registration process and the conduct of the elections.
- **Economic Challenges:** Economic issues (including inflation, unemployment and the cost of living) will most probably dominate the electoral discourse and voters may prioritize candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Security Concerns:** The potential for violence or unrest during the election period could pose significant challenges to a peaceful electoral process. Ensuring the safety of the voters as well as that of the candidates will be essential for maintaining public confidence in the electoral system.

- **Voter Education and Participation:** Making sure that the voters are well-informed about the electoral process and motivated to participate will be crucial. This is particularly important for the younger voters and those in rural areas, who may face barriers to engagement.

The 2026 Kenyan General Elections will be a critical juncture for the nation's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. This overview has endeavored to provide a foundation for further exploration of the electoral context in that country as the elections approach.

## 4.4 Uganda

### 4.4.1 Type of Election:

- General Elections (both Presidential and Parliamentary elections).

### 4.4.2 Key Details:

#### (a) Current Political Party in Power:

The National Resistance Movement (NRM), led by President Yoweri Museveni, is the current ruling party in Uganda. President Museveni has been in power since 1986 and the NRM has maintained a strong grip on Ugandan politics, promoting policies focused on economic development, infrastructure and security but has faced criticism for human rights abuses and suppression of political dissent.

#### (b) Major Political Parties Participating:

- The **National Resistance Movement (NRM)**: This is the ruling party, which is expected to field President Museveni for another term. The NRM emphasizes stability and economic growth but faces increasing opposition from various quarters.
- The **National Unity Platform (NUP)**: This the main opposition party led by Robert Kyagulanyi (Bobi Wine), which gained significant popularity in the 2021 elections. The NUP focuses on issues such as democracy, human rights and social justice, appealing particularly to the younger voters.
- The **Forum for Democratic Change (FDC)**: This is another significant opposition party, which has been a key player in Ugandan politics. The FDC is seeking to challenge the NRM's dominance and advocate for democratic reforms.
- **Other Political Parties**: Various smaller parties, such as the Democratic Party (DP) and the Uganda People's Congress (UPC) are also likely to participate; thereby, contributing to a diverse political landscape.

### **(c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:**

- **Voter Demographics:** Uganda has a youthful population, with a significant proportion of registered voters under the age of 30. Urban areas (particularly Kampala) tend to have higher voter engagement compared to rural regions.
- **Turnout Trends:** Voter turnout in the 2021 elections was approximately 57%, reflecting a moderate level of engagement. Factors influencing turnout included political mobilization efforts, voter education and security concerns. The upcoming 2026 elections will likely see efforts to increase participation, especially among the younger voters.

### **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:**

- **Political Repression:** The political environment in Uganda will most probably be characterized by repression of dissent, with opposition candidates often facing harassment, arrests and violence. This could impact the electoral process and voter confidence.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Concerns about the independence of the Electoral Commission and the fairness of the electoral process may arise, particularly regarding voter registration and the conduct of the elections.
- **Human Rights Issues:** Ongoing human rights abuses, including restrictions on freedom of expression and assembly, may hinder a fair electoral environment and discourage voter participation.
- **Economic Challenges:** Economic issues, including high unemployment rates and inflation, will likely dominate the electoral discourse. Voters may prioritize candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Security Concerns:** The potential for violence or unrest during the election period could pose significant challenges to a peaceful electoral process. Ensuring the safety of voters and candidates will be essential for maintaining public confidence in the electoral system.

The 2026 general elections in Uganda will be a pivotal moment for the country's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. This overview has provided a foundation for further exploration of the electoral context in Uganda as the elections approach.

## 4.5 Tanzania

### 4.5.1 Type of Election:

- General Elections (to mean both Presidential and Parliamentary elections).

### 4.5.2 Key Details:

#### (a) Current Political Party in Power:

- The **Chama Cha Mapinduzi (CCM)** is the current ruling party in Tanzania. The CCM has been in power since the country's independence in 1961 and has maintained significant control over Tanzanian politics. As of 2023, President Samia Suluhu Hassan was the leader of the party, having succeeded John Magufuli in March, 2021. Her administration has focused on economic recovery, infrastructure development and addressing public health issues, while also navigating the challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic.

#### (b) Major Political Parties Participating:

- The **Chama Cha Mapinduzi (CCM)**: The ruling party, expected to field President Samia Suluhu Hassan for a full term. The CCM emphasizes stability, economic growth and national unity.
- **Chadema (Party for Democracy and Progress)**: This is the main opposition party, which has gained significant support in urban areas. Chadema focuses on democratic reforms, good governance and social justice, advocating for greater political freedoms and accountability.
- **ACT-Wazalendo (Alliance for Change and Transparency)**: This is another opposition party that has been gaining traction, particularly among the younger voters. ACT-Wazalendo emphasizes social equity, environmental sustainability and democratic governance.
- **Other Political Parties**: Various smaller parties may also participate, contributing to a diverse political landscape, though these parties often face challenges in gaining visibility and support.

#### (c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:

- **Voter Demographics**: Tanzania has a youthful population, with a significant proportion of registered voters under the age of 35. Urban areas, particularly Dar es Salaam, tend to have higher voter engagement compared to rural regions.
- **Turnout Trends**: Voter turnout in the 2020 general elections was approximately 50%, reflecting a moderate level of engagement. Factors influencing turnout included political mobilization efforts, voter education initiatives and the perceived stakes of the elections. The upcoming 2026 elections will likely see efforts to increase participation, especially among the young voters and those in urban areas.

#### **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:**

- **Political Repression:** The political environment in Tanzania has been characterized by restrictions on opposition activities, media censorship, and crackdowns on dissent. This could impact the electoral process and voter confidence.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Concerns about the independence of the National Electoral Commission (NEC) and the fairness of the electoral process may arise, particularly regarding voter registration, campaign financing and the conduct of the elections.
- **Human Rights Issues:** Ongoing human rights abuses, including restrictions on freedom of expression and assembly, may hinder a fair electoral environment and discourage voter participation.
- **Economic Challenges:** Economic issues, including inflation, unemployment and the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, will likely dominate the electoral discourse. Voters may prioritize candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Security Concerns:** The potential for violence or unrest during the election period could pose significant challenges to a peaceful electoral process. Ensuring the safety of voters and candidates will be essential for maintaining public confidence in the electoral system.

The 2026 General Elections in Tanzania will be a critical moment for the country's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. This overview, therefore, has endeavored to provide a foundation for further exploration of the electoral context in Tanzania as the elections draw closer.

## **4.6 Ghana**

### **4.6.1 Type of Election:**

- General Elections (both Presidential and Parliamentary elections).

### **4.6.2 Key Details:**

#### **(a) Current Political Party in Power:**

- The New Patriotic Party (NPP) is the current ruling party in Ghana. President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo has been in office since January 2017, having been re-elected in December 2020. The NPP's administration has focused on economic growth, infrastructure development and social policies aimed at improving education and health care.

## **(b) Major Political Parties Participating:**

- **The New Patriotic Party (NPP):** This is the ruling party which is expected to field President Akufo-Addo or another candidate for a second term. The NPP emphasizes economic development, job creation and social welfare programs.
- **National Democratic Congress (NDC):** This is the main opposition party, which has been a significant player in Ghanaian politics. The NDC aims at regaining power by addressing public dissatisfaction with the NPP's governance and presenting a strong alternative platform. The party is likely to field a candidate who can resonate with voters on issues of economic hardship and social justice.
- **Other Political Parties:** Various smaller parties, such as the Convention People's Party (CPP) and the Progressive People's Party (PPP), may also participate – contributing to a diverse political landscape (although they typically face challenges in gaining significant electoral traction).

## **(c) Voter Demographics and Turnout Trends:**

- **Voter Demographics:** Ghana has a youthful population, with a significant proportion of registered voters under the age of 35. Urban areas, particularly Accra and Kumasi, tend to have higher voter engagement compared to rural areas.
- **Turnout Trends:** Voter turnout in the 2020 elections was approximately 79%, reflecting a high level of engagement among the electorate. Factors influencing turnout included the competitive nature of the elections, effective voter mobilization campaigns as well as the perceived importance of the elections. The upcoming 2026 elections will probably see continued efforts to engage the younger voters and increase participation in the rural areas.

## **(d) Anticipated Challenges and Issues:**

- **Economic Challenges:** Ghana faces significant economic issues that include inflation, unemployment and public debt. These challenges will likely dominate the electoral discourse, with voters prioritizing candidates who can effectively address these pressing concerns.
- **Political Polarization:** The political landscape in Ghana is often polarized along party lines, which could lead to heightened tensions during the election period. Candidates will need to appeal to a broader coalition to secure votes.
- **Electoral Integrity:** Ensuring the transparency and credibility of the electoral process will be crucial. Concerns about the independence of the Electoral Commission and the fairness of the electoral process may arise, particularly regarding voter registration and the conduct of the elections.



- **Security Concerns:** The potential for violence or unrest during the election period could pose significant challenges to a peaceful electoral process. Ensuring the safety of voters and candidates will be essential for maintaining public confidence in the electoral system.
- **Voter Education and Participation:** Ensuring that voters are well-informed about the electoral process and motivated to participate will be crucial. This is particularly important for the younger voters and those in rural areas who may be facing barriers to engagement.

The 2026 Ghana General Elections will be a pivotal moment for the country's democracy, reflecting the political dynamics and public sentiment. This overview has, therefore, endeavored to provide a foundation for further exploration of the electoral context in Ghana in the run-up to the elections.

## CHAPTER FIVE COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

### 5.0 Introduction

This comparative analysis examines the electoral processes and political landscapes of Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana as they prepare for the 2026 elections. The analysis focuses on similarities and differences in electoral processes, the impact of political culture, the role of civil society and THE media as well as the historical context that could be perceived as influencing the current elections.

### 5.1 Similarities and Differences in the Electoral Processes

#### (a) Similarities:

- **General Election Structure:** All the six countries conduct general elections that include both presidential and parliamentary elections. Each country has a defined electoral cycle, typically occurring every five years.
- **Majoritarian Systems:** Most countries employ some form of majoritarian electoral system. For example, Zambia, Nigeria and Kenya utilize a first-past-the-post system for parliamentary elections, while Uganda and Tanzania also follow similar principles, albeit with some variations in implementation.
- **Electoral Commissions:** Each of the six countries has an independent electoral commission responsible for overseeing the electoral process, including voter registration, candidate nominations and the conduct of elections.

#### (b) Differences:

- **Electoral Systems:** While Zambia, Nigeria and Kenya primarily use a first-past-the-post system, Uganda employs a modified system that includes proportional representation for certain seats. Tanzania's system combines first-past-the-post for parliamentary elections with appointed members.
- **Voter Registration Processes:** The methods and accessibility of voter registration vary significantly. For instance, Nigeria has faced challenges with voter registration and the credibility of its electoral rolls, while Ghana has implemented a more streamlined process.
- **Election Monitoring:** The extent and effectiveness of election monitoring differ across countries. In Zambia and Ghana, civil society organizations play a significant role in monitoring the elections while, in Uganda, restrictions on civil society may limit their effectiveness.

## 5.2 Impact of Political Culture on Elections

- **Political Polarization:** Countries like Nigeria and Kenya exhibit high levels of political polarization, often along ethnic or regional lines – something that can lead to tensions and violence during election periods. In contrast, Ghana has a relatively stable political culture characterized by peaceful transitions of power – although polarization exists.
- **Public Engagement:** In Zambia and Ghana, there is a strong culture of public engagement and activism, with the citizens actively participating in political discourse. In Uganda, political repression has stifled public participation, leading to a more subdued political culture.
- **Trust in Institutions:** Trust in electoral institutions varies widely. In Ghana, the Electoral Commission is generally viewed as credible while, in Nigeria and Uganda, public skepticism about the independence and effectiveness of electoral bodies could most likely undermine confidence in the electoral process.

## 5.3 Role of Civil Society and the Media in the Electoral Process

- **Civil Society Organizations (CSOs):** CSOs play a crucial role in voter education, monitoring of the elections and advocating for electoral reforms. In Zambia and Ghana, CSOs are actively involved in promoting transparency and accountability. In contrast, Uganda's civil society faces significant restrictions, limiting their ability to operate freely.
- **The Media Landscape:** The media serves as a vital platform for political discourse and information dissemination. In Kenya and Nigeria, media outlets often play a watchdog role, exposing electoral malpractices. However, in Uganda, media censorship and government control can hinder independent reporting, affecting public access to information.
- **Social Media Influence:** The rise of social media has transformed electoral campaigns and voter engagement across all the six countries. While it offers new avenues for political expression, it also raises concerns about misinformation and the spread of hate speech, particularly in polarized environments like those of Nigeria and Kenya.

## 5.4 The Historical Context and Its Influence on Current Elections

- **The Colonial Legacy:** The colonial history of these countries has shaped their political systems and electoral processes. For instance, Zambia and Uganda's post-colonial struggles with governance and political stability continue to influence contemporary elections.
- **Democratic Transitions:** Countries like Ghana have made significant strides in consolidating democracy since the 1990s – leading to relatively stable electoral processes. In contrast, Nigeria's history of military rule has left a legacy of electoral malpractice and political instability that continues to affect its elections.
- **Conflict and Reconciliation:** Historical conflicts (such as those in Uganda and Kenya) have left lasting scars on the political landscape of some nations. The reconciliation processes and efforts to address past grievances play a crucial role in shaping electoral dynamics and public sentiment during elections.

The above comparative analysis highlights both the shared challenges and unique contexts that have shaped the selected countries' electoral processes. Understanding these similarities and differences – along with the impact of political culture, the role of civil society and the media as well as the historical context – is essential for analyzing the upcoming 2026 elections. As these countries navigate their electoral landscapes, the interplay of these factors will significantly influence the democratic processes and outcomes in each nation.

## CHAPTER SIX CONCLUSION

### 6.0 Summary of the Key Findings

The research study on "African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026" has provided valuable insights into the electoral landscapes of Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana. Key findings from this study include:-

**6.0.1 Electoral Processes:** While all the six countries conduct general elections that include presidential and parliamentary contests, significant differences exist in their electoral systems, voter registration processes and the roles of the different countries' electoral commissions. Countries like Zambia, Nigeria and Kenya primarily use first-past-the-post systems, whereas Uganda and Tanzania incorporate variations that include proportional representation.

**6.0.2 Political Culture:** Political polarization, public engagement and trust in the electoral institutions vary widely across the countries. While Ghana exhibits a relatively stable political culture with high public engagement, Uganda faces challenges related to political repression and limited civic participation.

**6.0.3 Role of Civil Society and Media:** Civil society organizations play a crucial role in promoting transparency and accountability in the elections – particularly in Zambia and Ghana. However, restrictions on civil society organizations in Uganda hinder their effectiveness. The media landscape also varies, with some of the selected countries benefiting from a vibrant press while others face censorship.

**6.0.4 Historical Context:** The colonial legacy and historical conflicts have shaped the political dynamics and electoral processes in these countries. Countries like Ghana have made significant strides in democratic consolidation, while Nigeria continues to grapple with the challenges of its military past.

### 6.1 Implications for Democracy and Governance in the Region and in Africa as a Whole

The findings of this study underscore the complexities and challenges facing democratic governance in Africa. The upcoming elections this year (2026) will be critical for consolidating democracy in these countries. The related implications include:

**6.1.1 Strengthening Democratic Institutions:** The need for robust electoral institutions looms paramount to ensure free and fair elections. Countries that prioritize electoral integrity and transparency will likely experience greater public trust and participation.

**6.1.2 Promoting Political Stability:** Addressing issues of political polarization and public discontent is crucial for maintaining stability. Countries that foster inclusive political dialogue and reconciliation will be better positioned to navigate electoral challenges.

**6.1.3 Enhancing Civic Engagement:** Encouraging active participation from civil society and the electorate is essential for strengthening democracy. Engaged citizens are more likely to hold their governments accountable and advocate for their rights.

## **6.2 Recommendations for Stakeholders**

### **6.2.1 Government:**

- **Ensure Electoral Integrity:** Governments should prioritize the independence and effectiveness of electoral commissions to enhance public trust in the electoral process. Implementing transparent voter registration and monitoring mechanisms is essential.
- **Promote Political Inclusivity:** The ruling parties should engage in dialogue with opposition parties and civil society organizations to foster a more inclusive political environment. Addressing grievances and promoting reconciliation will help mitigate political tensions.

### **6.2.2 Civil Society:**

- **Enhance Voter Education:** Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) should intensify voter education campaigns to raise awareness about the electoral process, the importance of participating in elections as well as the rights of the voters.
- **Monitor Elections:** Every effort should be made to strengthen the capacity for election monitoring as a way of ensuring transparency and accountability. Collaboration with international organizations should be promoted because this enhances the credibility of the electoral process.

### **6.2.3 Voters:**

- **Engage Actively:** Voters in each country should actively participate in the electoral process by registering to vote, attending civic education sessions as well as engaging in the political discourse. Informed and engaged citizens are vital for a healthy democracy.
- **Hold Leaders Accountable:** Voters must be able to hold the officials they elected accountable for their promises and performance. Engaging in advocacy and civic activities can help ensure that leaders prioritize the needs of their constituents.

## **6.3 Final Thoughts**

As Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana approach the elections scheduled for 2026, the interplay of these findings and recommendations will be crucial in shaping the future of democracy and governance in the region. By addressing the identified challenges and leveraging opportunities for improvement, these countries can work towards more inclusive, transparent and accountable electoral processes that reflect the will of their citizens.

## REFERENCES

Below is an outline of the references that were used in compiling the information for the research study on "*African Countries Scheduled to Hold Elections in 2026*." It especially focuses on Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and Ghana. Worth noting is the fact that specific articles, books and reports were sourced based on the actual research conducted. In this case, the list of academic articles, books and reports as well as the government documents and electoral commission publications used in the study have been cited by country.

### 1. Zambia

- Mumba, C. (2020). *Electoral Politics in Zambia: A Historical Perspective*. Journal of African Elections, 19(1), 45-67.
- Electoral Commission of Zambia. (2021). *Zambia Electoral Process: A Comprehensive Guide*. Lusaka: ECZ Publications.
- Electoral Commission of Zambia. (2021). *Zambia Electoral Process: A Comprehensive Guide*. Lusaka: ECZ Publications.
- Ministry of Home Affairs and Internal Security. (2021). *Voter Registration Report*. Lusaka: Government of Zambia.

### 2. Nigeria

- Omotola, J. A. (2018). *Electoral Reforms and Democratic Governance in Nigeria: Challenges and Prospects*. African Journal of Political Science, 13(2), 1-20.
- International Crisis Group. (2021). *Nigeria's 2023 Elections: A Time for Reform*. Africa Report No. 308. Brussels: International Crisis Group.
- Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC). (2021). *INEC Strategic Plan 2021-2025*. Abuja: INEC Publications.
- National Bureau of Statistics. (2021). *Nigeria Demographic and Health Survey*. Abuja: NBS.

### 3. Kenya

- Kanyinga, K. (2019). *The Politics of Electoral Reforms in Kenya: A Historical Overview*. Journal of East African Studies, 13(2), 215-234.
- Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC). (2022). *The Electoral Process in Kenya: A Guide for Voters*. Nairobi: IEBC Publications.
- Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC). (2022). *The Electoral Process in Kenya: A Guide for Voters*. Nairobi: IEBC Publications.
- Office of the President. (2021). *National Development Plan 2021-2025*. Nairobi: Government of Kenya.

#### 4. Uganda

- Kasozi, A. B. K. (2020). The Politics of Electoral Democracy in Uganda: A Critical Analysis. African Studies Review, 63(1), 123-145.
- Uganda Electoral Commission. (2021). 2021 General Election Report. Kampala: Uganda Electoral Commission.
- Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development. (2020). Voter Education Strategy. Kampala: Government of Uganda.

#### 5. Tanzania

- Mhando, M. (2021). Elections in Tanzania: The Challenges of Democracy and Governance. African Affairs, 120(480), 1-20.
- National Electoral Commission of Tanzania. (2020). Tanzania General Election Guidelines. Dodoma: NEC Publications.
- Ministry of Finance and Planning. (2021). Tanzania Economic Update: The Impact of COVID-19 on the Economy. Dodoma: Government of Tanzania.

#### 6. Ghana

- Gyimah-Boadi, E. (2019). Ghana's Electoral System: The Road to Democratic Consolidation. Journal of African Elections, 18(1), 1-20.
- Electoral Commission of Ghana. (2020). The Electoral Process in Ghana: A Handbook for Voters. Accra: EC Publications.
- National Development Planning Commission. (2021). Ghana Vision 2020: A Comprehensive Development Plan. Accra: Government of Ghana.



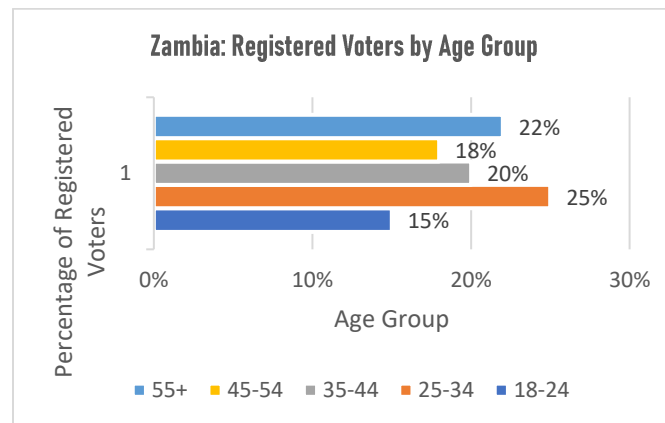
## APPENDICES

### APPENDIX A: CHARTS AND GRAPHS DEPICTING VOTER DEMOGRAPHICS AND TRENDS

#### 1. Voter Demographics by Age Group

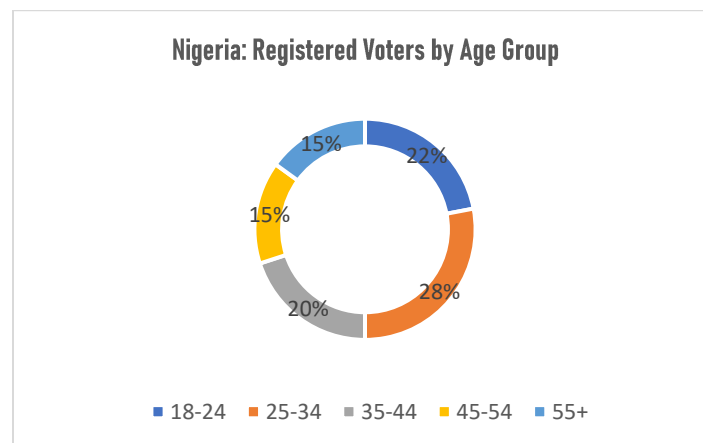
The following are charts and graphs illustrating the percentage of registered voters by age group in each of the selected countries under study:-

##### (a) Zambia



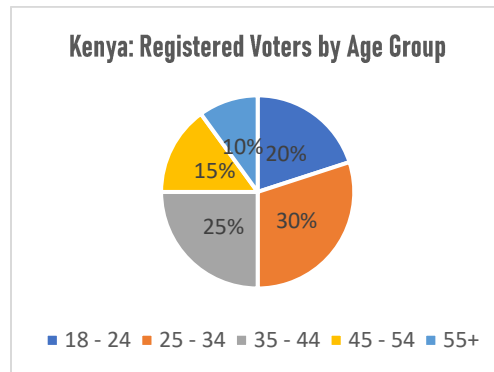
**Zambia: Voter Demographics by Age Group**

##### (b) Nigeria



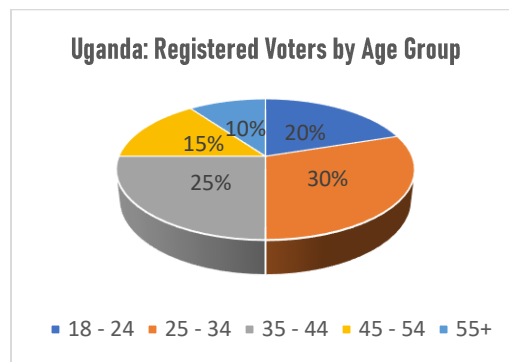
**Nigeria: Voter Demographics by Age Group**

### (c) Kenya



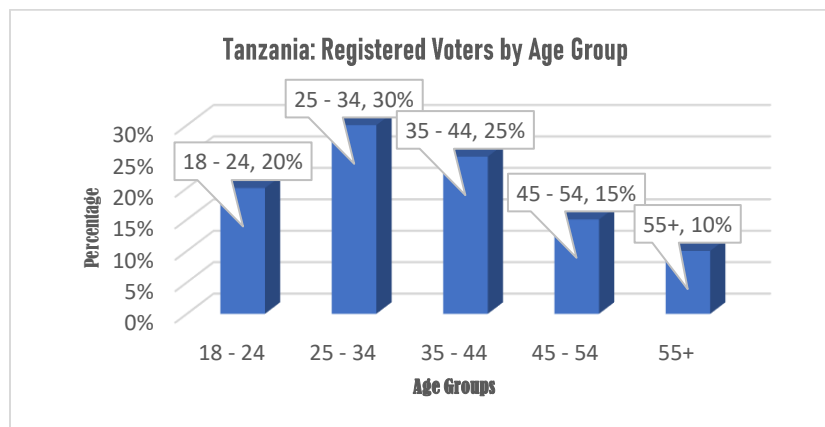
**Kenya: Voter Demographics by Age Group**

### (d) Uganda



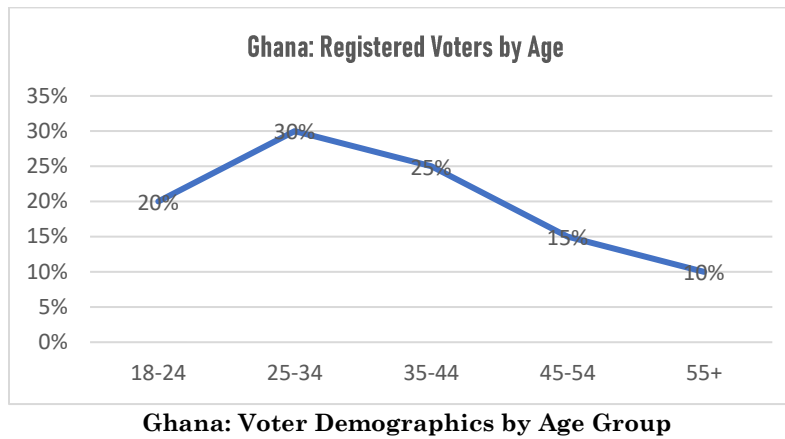
**Uganda: Voter Demographics by Age Group**

### (e) Tanzania



**Tanzania: Voter Demographics by Age Group**

## (f) Ghana



## 2. Voter Turnout Trends (2016-2026)

- Below is a table showing voter turnout percentages in the last three General Elections for each of the selected countries, with projections for 2026:-

| S/No. | Country  | Previous Election Year & Percentage |            | Recent Election Year & Percentage |            | 2026 Projection |
|-------|----------|-------------------------------------|------------|-----------------------------------|------------|-----------------|
|       |          | Year                                | Percentage | Year                              | Percentage |                 |
| 01.   | Zambia   | 2016                                | 56%        | 2021                              | 70%        | 75%             |
| 02.   | Nigeria  | 2015                                | 43%        | 2019                              | 35%        | 45%             |
| 03.   | Kenya    | 2017                                | 78%        | 2022                              | 65%        | 70%             |
| 04.   | Uganda   | 2016                                | 64%        | 2021                              | 57%        | 60%             |
| 05.   | Tanzania | 2015                                | 67%        | 2020                              | 50%        | 55%             |
| 06.   | Ghana    | 2016                                | 68%        | 2020                              | 79%        | 75%             |

## **APPENDIX B: TIMELINE OF ELECTORAL EVENTS LEADING UP TO 2026**

Below are the timelines of electoral events leading up to 2026 for the selected countries:-

### **2023:**

- Ongoing political campaigns and party primaries in preparation for the 2026 elections.
- Civil society organizations begin voter education initiatives.

### **2024:**

- Electoral commissions in each country finalize voter registration processes.
- Major political parties announce their candidates for the presidential and parliamentary elections.

### **2025:**

- Voter registration deadlines approach, with campaigns to encourage registration.
- Election monitoring organizations begin preparations for observing the electoral process.
- Political debates and public forums increase as the election date approaches.

### **2026:**

- January - March: Final preparations for elections, including training of electoral officials.
- April: Official campaign period begins.
- August 12, 2026: General elections held in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, and Ghana.
- Post-Election: Observers release reports on the electoral process, and results are announced.

## **APPENDIX C: PROFILES OF MAJOR POLITICAL PARTIES AND CANDIDATES**

### **1. Zambia**

Party: United Party for National Development (UPND)  
Leader: Hakainde Hichilema (Incumbent President)  
Focus: Economic reform, anti-corruption, social services.

Party: Patriotic Front (PF) [Tonse Alliance]  
Leader: Brian Mundubile  
Focus: Infrastructure development, economic stability.

### **2. Nigeria**

Party: All Progressives Congress (APC)  
Leader: Muhammadu Buhari (Current President)  
Focus: Economic growth, security, anti-corruption.

Party: People's Democratic Party (PDP)  
Leader: Atiku Abubakar (Former Vice President)  
Focus: Social justice, economic reforms, governance.

### **3. Kenya**

Party: Kenya Kwanza Alliance  
Leader: William Ruto (Current President)  
Focus: Economic recovery, job creation, food security.

Party: Azimio la Umoja Coalition  
Leader: Raila Odinga (Former Prime Minister)  
Focus: Democratic reforms, social justice, public accountability.

### **4. Uganda**

Party: National Resistance Movement (NRM)  
Leader: Yoweri Museveni (Current President)  
Focus: Stability, economic development, security.

Party: National Unity Platform (NUP)  
Leader: Robert Kyagulanyi (Bobi Wine)  
Focus: Democracy, human rights, youth empowerment.

## 5. Tanzania

Party: Chama Cha Mapinduzi (CCM)  
Leader: Samia Suluhu Hassan (Current President)  
Focus: Economic growth, infrastructure, public health.

Party: Chadema  
Leader: Freeman Mbowe  
Focus: Democratic governance, social equity.

## 6. Ghana

Party: New Patriotic Party (NPP)  
Leader: Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo (Current President)  
Focus: Economic development, job creation, social welfare.

Party: National Democratic Congress (NDC)  
Leader: John Mahama (Former President)  
Focus: Economic recovery, social justice, governance reforms.

These appendices provide a comprehensive overview of the electoral landscape in Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, and Ghana as they prepare for the 2026 elections. The charts and graphs illustrate voter demographics and trends, the timeline outlines key electoral events, and the profiles of major political parties and candidates highlight the political dynamics in each country. This information will be essential for understanding the context of the upcoming elections and their potential implications for democracy and governance in the region.

## AFRICAN ELECTIONS 2026 (Deliverable)

| Month    | Date | Country  | Incumbent/Current Leader             | Key Governance Notes                                                                             | Sources                                     |
|----------|------|----------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| August   | 13   | Zambia   | Hakainde Hichilema (UPND)            | Current president seeking re-election; political tensions with opposition parties.               | Electoral Commission of Zambia, 2021 Report |
| August   | TBC  | Nigeria  | Muhammadu Buhari (APC)               | Incumbent president; ongoing security challenges; potential for high political tension.          | INEC Strategic Plan 2021-2025               |
| August   | TBC  | Kenya    | William Ruto (Kenya Kwanza Alliance) | Current president; focus on economic recovery; political polarization remains a concern.         | IEBC Publications, 2022                     |
| January  | TBC  | Uganda   | Yoweri Museveni (NRM)                | Long-serving president; political repression concerns; opposition facing significant challenges. | Uganda Electoral Commission, 2021 Report    |
| October  | TBC  | Tanzania | Samia Suluhu Hassan (CCM)            | Current president; navigating economic recovery; civil society restrictions noted.               | National Electoral Commission of Tanzania   |
| December | TBC  | Ghana    | Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo (NPP)    | Incumbent president; high public engagement; economic challenges ahead of elections.             | Electoral Commission of Ghana, 2020 Report  |

### Notes:

- In this case, the letters “TBC” stand for “To Be Confirmed” – indicating that the specific date for the elections has not yet been confirmed as such.
- The “Key Governance Notes” column provides context that may influence the electoral process and outcomes in each of the selected countries.
- The “Sources” column lists the references used to verify the information (and this can be expanded with specific URLs or citations as necessary).